government and ₹21.88 lakh by various government departments situated in these areas.[7]

When Modi briefed a journalist in May 2007 about his pre-election campaign approach, he too highlighted the mahila sammelans. Through these—and other such targeted events, like vanbandhu sammelans (forest friend, or Adivasi, meetings) and sagarkhedu (seafarer) sammelans—Modi estimated that he had addressed over 28 lakh women in a two-month period before the ECI's announcement of poll dates.[8]

Modi as a 'Sex Symbol': Masculinity, the 'Chhappanee Chhatee' Discourse and Outreach on Women's Issues

The genesis of Modi's 2007 political outreach to Gujarati women lay in how the crowds had responded to him in 2002 during his first election campaign. That was when he first evolved a language of political machismo. Modi's public references to his 'chhappanee chhatee' (fifty-six-inch chest) became the signature of a new political persona, along with a new discourse of 'asmita' (Gujarati pride). In an election in which the chief minister accused those who raised questions about the post-Godhra riots of maligning '5 crore Gujaratis', he simultaneously presented himself as the manly defender of Gujarati pride.[9] Looking back, as a TV journalist following Modi's Gaurav Yatra (Pride Journey) between September and December 2002, the one thing that stood out was how often he used the phrase 'chhappanee chhatee' in his speeches as he traversed the state in a modified bus, starting from the Bhatiji temple in Mehsana's Phagvel to Godhra and back to Ahmedabad.[10] In a speech he delivered in Godhra in October 2002, a colleague did the count: the chief minister had mentioned his 'chhappanee chhatee' over a dozen times. He was clearly positioning himself as the masculine defender of Gujarati and Hindu pride. This is why the most common slogan one heard every time Modi entered an election rally in 2002 was: '*Dekho dekho kaun aaya, Gujarat ka sher aaya* [Look, look, who has come, the lion of Gujarat has come]'. We had first heard this slogan earlier that year when he arrived at the